PHIL 2220 – Essay Assignment
Spring 2026

Write a 1500- to 1800-word essay (5–6 pages) on the following topic. **Do not use so-called "artificial intelligence" or anything like it.** Take the time to work through this on your own, with reading, note-taking, and typing. The essay is due on ~~Wed., April 22 by 9:59pm~~ **Fri., April 24 by 9:59pm**.

To minimize technological snafus, you are required to submit your essay ***twice***:

- on Canvas
- by email, using CC so that it is sent both to your lecturer and to your TA

At the following address, you'll find a lengthy excerpt (Chapter V, Section I) from William King's *Origin of Evil* (1702); read the highlighted parts carefully (especially those parts you choose to write on), and at least skim the non-highlighted parts:

https://colemitchell.github.io/PHIL2220/essay.html

The excerpt is about "Elections and Liberty"; but it's not about politics, it's about what we now label "free will". To slightly simplify, the excerpt has the following structure:

Subsection I:	King presents and criticizes a theory (seven criticisms)
Subsection II:	King presents and criticizes another theory (five criticisms)
Subsection III:	King presents his own theory (twelve points)
Subsection IV:	King argues that his theory applies to God (six main points)
Subsection V:	King argues that his theory applies to humans (three general points, several subpoints)

Here's how to structure your essay:

Part A:
1. Briefly describe both of the two theories King rejects in Subsections I and II.
2. Choose one of these two theories, describe in more detail how it's supposed to work, and briefly explain two of King's criticisms. (You can ignore the other theory.)

Part B:
1. Drawing (at least primarily) on Subsection III, describe how King's theory is supposed to work in general.
2. Choose whether to write on Subsection IV or Subsection V, and do the following:

Subsection IV:	Subsection V:
Identify a potential problem with applying King's theory to God: - This could be a simple matter of implausible or unwanted implications - Alternatively, it could be that King is vulnerable to a criticism he made of the other two theories - Or it could be that King's supporting argument is flawed	Identify a potential problem with applying King's theory to humans: - This could be a simple matter of implausible or unwanted implications - Alternatively, it could be that King is vulnerable to a criticism he made of the other two theories - Or it could be that King's supporting argument is flawed
Explain how King might try to solve this problem	Explain how King might try to solve this problem
Assess whether such a solution would work	Assess whether such a solution would work

Pointers and guidelines:

- Just use standard formatting: Times New Roman or Calibri, 12-point font, double spacing, normal 1" margins.
- It's okay to go a bit over 6 pages, but please (for your TA's sake) keep it under 8 pages.
- Do not use any other sources. You need not bother with citations or a bibliography. If you feel like practicing citations, you can have something like: *On King's account, the will is "indifferent in respect of the Objects about which it exercises itself" (5.1.3.4)*. Or: *This theory, King writes, treats crimes as mere "Miseries" or "Misfortunes" (5.1.1.14).*
- Try to make your prose style simple, clear, precise, and reader-friendly. Don't try to impress anyone with your honeyed eloquence or rich vocabulary. Don't pretend to understand something that you don't.
- Try to put things in your own words, perhaps rearranging King's explanations, so that what you write ends up clearer and easier to understand than what he wrote.
- Do not write any introduction or conclusion. Doing so tends to tempt students into writing "Since the dawn of time…"-style filler that only annoys graders. Feel free to start with e.g. "In Subsections I and II of William King's *Origin of Evil*, …".
- Before writing anything, get clear on which positions are being supported or criticized in the argumentation. Try to make this clear to the reader.
- If you find yourself doing any argument reconstruction, remember the logic module:
    - The premises are supposed to provide support for the conclusion.
    - Not everything written down in the text needs to be a premise in the argument (e.g., sometimes there are mere illustrative examples, mere background information, mere concessions to the opposition).
    - Sometimes there are initial premises that support a *preliminary* conclusion, which in turn serves as a premise in support of the *final* conclusion.
    - If an argument seems invalid, consider whether there are any obvious suppressed premises and determine what changes could be made to render the argument valid (i.e., to make the conclusion logically follow from the premises).
    - Rearranging the elements of an argument—i.e., putting its propositions in a different order from that in the text—can make the argument clearer to the reader. Most obviously, put the conclusion last.
- When critically evaluating an argument, try to consider whether the premises are likely to be accepted by the historical participants in the discussion, or whether they stand in need of further support or defense against obvious counter-example. You can also set aside the historical participants and consider whether you can see any good reason to think the premises are true or false.
- Do not preface an objection with a hollow compliment: e.g., "Although this argument is well put and is very persuasive, it has a serious flaw". These people are dead and you will not hurt their feelings.
- It is sometimes useful to illustrate a point with a concrete example, but it isn't necessary.
- Do not apply the words 'valid', 'invalid', 'sound', or 'unsound' to a premise or a conclusion. These words are applied to a whole argument. And of course you can even decide to avoid the words entirely.

Each student in this course is expected to abide by the Cornell University Code of Academic Integrity. Any work submitted by a student in this course for academic credit will be the student's own work.